

Top 10 Castles of England and Wales

[B2]

Visitare tutti i castelli dell'Inghilterra e del Galles è un'impresa quasi impossibile: ce ne sono centinaia! Per semplificare le cose, ecco i nostri dieci preferiti. Un tuffo nella storia, nel mistero e nella bellezza.



Castles represent some of the most impressive structures of the medieval period. These constructions, built for defence, [display](#) of wealth and power (or often both), are [enduring](#) symbols of historical significance, architectural [splendour](#) and cultural impact. Across England and Wales, there are over two thousand castles in various states of conservation; from majestic fortresses and UNESCO World Heritage Sites to romantic ruins and hidden gems. This is our selection of the ten best castles in England and Wales.

1. WINDSOR CASTLE (ENGLAND)

Windsor Castle. The oldest and largest inhabited castle in the world, Windsor Castle has been the official residence of the British monarch for over nine hundred years. Located about 40km west of London, Windsor Castle [overlooks](#) the River Thames and serves as a working palace and cultural treasure. [Dating back to](#) 1070, the castle has [withstood](#) wars, fires, and centuries of change. Norman military architecture [blends](#) with [lavish](#) Georgian and Victorian interiors. Don't miss the grand State Apartments and Gothic St. George's [Chapel](#), where Prince Harry and Meghan Markle were married.

2. CAERNARFON CASTLE (WALES)

Caernarfon Castle. One of Britain's most ambitious castles, Caernarfon Castle is located on the [banks](#) of the River Seiont, overlooking the Menai [Strait](#). Begun in 1283, Caernarfon was part of Edward I's infamous Iron Ring of Castles in Wales. Its polygonal towers and walls were designed to evoke the grandeur of imperial Rome and to symbolise the [might](#) of the English over the Welsh. In 1969, King Charles III, then Prince Charles, was invested here as the Prince of Wales.

3. DOVER CASTLE (ENGLAND)

Dover Castle. Known as the Key to England, Dover Castle has guarded the UK's shortest sea crossing to continental Europe for over two thousand years. Its Great Tower was designed to impress visitors and [deter](#) invaders. Started in 1066, and expanded by Henry II, the castle was built over earlier Roman and Saxon fortifications. Dover's strategic significance saw the castle play a vital role in both World Wars. Its secret tunnels, medieval defences, and commanding [cliff-top](#) views make it one of Britain's most [dramatic](#) historic sites.

4. CONWY CASTLE (WALES)

Conwy Castle Conwy Castle is one of the most complete and best-preserved medieval fortresses in Europe. Constructed by Edward I between 1283 and 1287, during his conquest of Wales, it [boasts](#) eight massive towers and a commanding

position above the River Conwy in Gwynedd. Its concentric walls, [cleverly](#) constructed defences, and [integral link](#) to Conwy's walled town provide a masterclass in military architecture. Its [stark](#) beauty and mountainous [backdrop](#) make this one of the most picturesque castles in Wales.

5. WARWICK CASTLE (ENGLAND)

Warwick Castle. Warwick Castle evolved from William the Conqueror's [motte-and-bailey](#) into one of England's grandest and most romantic medieval castles. Begun in 1068, it was later transformed by the powerful Beauchamp family into a [lavish](#) residence and military [stronghold](#). Located on the River Avon in Warwickshire, its imposing towers, [dungeons](#) and restored interiors provide immersive historical experiences. A major [heritage](#) attraction, with magnificent gardens, it [blends](#) authentic history with family-friendly appeal, offering a vivid window into life during England's tumultuous medieval period. Places

Top 5: Scottish Castles Questa che vi presentiamo è una tra le tante possibili selezioni di castelli scozzesi. Di alcuni di loro restano ormai solo le rovine, anche a causa del clima inclemente, mentre altri sono stati restaurati, contribuendo alla fama di una nazione che fu scenario di cruenti scontri politici e religiosi. Julian Earwaker, Sarah Davison

6. BAMBURGH CASTLE (ENGLAND)

Bamburgh Castle. Overlooking the North Sea and a sandy beach, Bamburgh Castle has guarded the Northumberland coast for over 1,400 years. Once the royal [seat](#) of the Anglo-Saxon kings of Northumbria, it was rebuilt as a Norman [stronghold](#) and later restored by the Victorian industrialist William Armstrong. Its [sweeping](#) sea views, vast [keep](#), and atmospheric halls showcase centuries of border [warfare](#) and noble [heritage](#). Bamburgh's location and resilience against time and [tide](#) make it one of the most iconic castles in Britain.

7. BODIAM CASTLE (ENGLAND)

Bodiam Castle. Bodiam is a quintessential [fairytale moated castle](#). Built in 1385 by Sir Edward Dalyngrigge to defend against French invasion during the Hundred Years' War, it was designed for both show and protection. With its perfect symmetry, rounded towers, and wide moat reflecting its romantic silhouette, Bodiam [blends](#) military design with late medieval luxury. Located in Robertsbridge, East Sussex, the ruins of the [inner courtyard](#) and [stunning](#) views from the [battlements](#) [lend](#) Bodiam a [haunting](#) yet romantic [charm](#).

8. TINTAGEL CASTLE (ENGLAND)

[Perched](#) on top of [rugged cliffs](#) along Cornwall's wild north coast, Tintagel [blends](#) both history and myth. This is the legendary birthplace of King Arthur, although the castle standing today dates from the 13th century, and was built by Richard, [Earl](#) of Cornwall. It has an elemental and [dramatic](#) setting, connected to the mainland by a narrow [footbridge](#) across a deep [gorge](#). Archaeological discoveries of early Dark Age remains make Tintagel a powerful symbol of Britain's ancient and mythical past.

9. ORFORD CASTLE (ENGLAND)

Orford Castle. Orford Castle is a unique Norman fortress on the Suffolk coast, east of Ipswich. It was built by Henry II in the 12th century to assert royal authority in turbulent times. Its polygonal [keep](#) is an architectural marvel, [blending](#) innovation with military function: a near-perfect, circular core surrounded by three tower-like [buttresses](#), [unlike](#) anything else in England. With spiral staircases, atmospheric chambers, and panoramic views over [eerie](#) Orford [Ness](#), the castle symbolises medieval power, strategy, and coastal defence.

10. ARUNDEL CASTLE (ENGLAND)

Arundel Castle. Combining Norman origins with Gothic grandeur, Arundel Castle, in West Sussex, has evolved from medieval fortress to [stately home](#). Founded in 1067 as the [seat](#) of the powerful Dukes of Norfolk, who still live there today, the castle was extensively restored in the 19th century. Its powerful [keep](#), majestic [gatehouse](#), and [lavish](#) interiors filled with art, armour, and history are set high above the River Arun, surrounded by landscaped gardens. Arundel [blends](#) military [might](#) with an aristocratic legacy. If you want to know more about this topic, read the article Castles Of England And Wales: Theatres Of History.

Glossary

- **lavish** = sfarzosi
- **keep** = mastio (torre principale di un castello)
- **battlements** = merlature
- **Chapel** = cappella
- **might** = potenza, forza
- **cleverly** = ingegnosamente
- **integral link** = collegamento importante
- **stark** = severa, essenziale
- **moated castle** = castello circondato da un fossato
- **inner courtyard** = cortile interno
- **buttresses** = contrafforti
- **display** = mostra, esibizione
- **Strait** = stretto
- **eerie** = inquietante, misterioso
- **Ness** = promontorio, luogo di confine
- **stately home** = dimora signorile
- **warfare** = attività bellica
- **overlooks** = affacciarsi
- **deter** = scoraggiare, dissuadere
- **cliff-top** = in cima alla scogliera
- **dramatic** = spettacolare, suggestivo
- **motte-and-bailey** = motta castrale (tipo di fortificazione medievale)
- **stronghold** = roccaforte
- **dungeons** = segrete, prigioni sotterranee
- **withstood** = resistere
- **heritage** = patrimonio
- **blends** = mescolare
- **stunning** = mozzafiato
- **charm** = fascino
- **footbridge** = passerella pedonale
- **gorge** = gola
- **gatehouse** = ingresso fortificato
- **banks** = rive
- **tide** = marea
- **haunting** = suggestivo
- **rudded cliffs** = scogliere frastagliate
- **unlike** = a differenza di
- **enduring** = duraturi
- **Dating back to** = risalire a
- **boasts** = vantare

- **backdrop** = sfondo
- **sweeping** = ampie, vaste
- **Earl** = conte
- **seat** = sede, dimora
- **fairytale** = fiabesco
- **lend** = conferire
- **Perched** = arroccato